known as the Myanmar National Democratic Alliance Army, were the first to agree to a ceasefire when the Communist Party of Burma imploded in the late 1980s. Their "Shan State Special Region 1" is centered on the borderlands town of Laukkai. Like the KIA-controlled territories in Kachin State, it prospered under the unusual economic and political conditions of ceasefire. The Kokang maintained a reputation as a group with strong links to the regional narcotics business, especially opium cultivation and amphetamine production. The Myanmar government, while sometimes active in its efforts to stop the drug trade, also tolerated the Kokang presence. Part of the explanation for this cosy arrangement is the Chinese government's support for the ethnic-Chinese Kokang. While designated as one of Myanmar's "national races", the Kokang continue to speak Chinese and maintain a wide range of cross-border connections, as seen when the Myanmar government launched offensives against the MNDAA in recent years. Kokang refugees fleeing to China received support not made available to other ethnic groups in similarly desperate circumstances.

The most complicated situation in Myanmar's borderlands still relates to the United Wa State Army, which may have around 20,000 fighters (Ei Ei Toe Lwin and Htoo Thant 2015; Ferguson 2010). It is the best-provisioned ethnic armed group in the country, with a level of technical and industrial capacity that challenges even the Myanmar government itself. For that reason, the Wa are persistently problematic for the central authorities. While open warfare has been rare, the tentative ceasefire that holds in their areas of Shan State is among the country's most fragile. Chinese support for the UWSA is one reason that Sino-Myanmar relations are a challenge for both sides. The Wa are also alleged contributors to the production of narcotics and the United States sanctions their top leaders for running a "narco-army". Indeed their business allegedly ranges from ordinary consumer goods and raw materials through to the illicit flows of weapons, people, and drugs (Chin 2009; Lintner 1994). Making this formidable strategic and commercial force fit the needs of Myanmar's centralising government is a long-term political and military headache.

Careful management of rebellious groups is apparent further south, where some ethnic armed forces continue to antagonise the government from their bases along the Thai border. Since the late 1940s this "buffer" region has proved beyond the comprehensive control of central governments from either side of the frontier. Such a complicated strategic dynamic has encouraged discreet Thai support for insurgent groups that fight the